Conceptual Clarity is the Basis for Advancing a Research Field

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Abstract submitted to: Theory Methods Conference 2026, Tilburg

Conceptual clarity is the basis for advancing a research field. This is exemplified in research on Classroom Peer Ecology, defined as "*a microsystem, 'the ultimate mechanism through which development occurs' (Bronfenbrenner, 1996, p. xv), which involves children interacting with, influencing, and socializing one another. [… providing] social regularities […] that organize and give stability to children's interpersonal behavior*" (Gest & Rodkin, 2011). While researchers have acknowledged the importance of the peer ecology for different student outcomes, the concept of peer ecologies as a whole has remained underspecified and lacking conceptual clarity. Specifically, there are two shortcomings of the literature. Firstly, there exists no exhaustive description of the dimensions peer ecologies differ on. Instead, different aspects of peer ecologies have been measured by social network parameters, holistically characterising the peer ecology (e.g., hierarchy, cohesion, fragmentation). Integrative research could help to relate the different network measures to the common dimensions they are aiming to capture. Such an integration would allow findings from different studies to be meaningfully compared and research to be accumulated, thereby strengthening theory building. Secondly, different network measures have been analytically shown to be related in complex ways and examining them in isolation might obscure the whole picture of antecedents and consequences of different types of peer ecologies. Therefore, a unit-centred, instead of variable-centred approach is warranted. The poster will present part of a research program aimed towards concept development in this field.